Germany and the Netherlands for a new and more effective mechanism to safeguard fundamental values in member states and had a first comprehensive discussion on the subject'.[202] At the time, I reported myself from The Hague about this idea with vigour, in a belief that such mechanism could help various European countries to deal with their different historical legacies. But by the time the idea developed into a quite influential mechanism, any hopes for a more sensitive, finely tuned instrument evaporated.

After all, similar totalitarian legacies, acting as potential obstacles to democratic development, may exist in other European countries that in the twentieth century experienced a totalitarian or authoritarian rule, although this is rarely talked about. We know of considerable post-World War II denazification efforts in Germany. Less zealous were political stakeholders in post-war Austria and Italy, where remnants of the past have in some quarters remained evident, for example, in the less than exemplary treatment of the Slovenian minority. (In Italy, even a rather benign turn to the right in Rome might in Trieste/Trst region translate into unfriendly minority policies. This is much more the case when such right parties are flirting with the Fascist legacy – something we should bear in mind at the moment.) Spanish transition and reconciliation was relatively widely publicised and could provide some useful advice to Central and Eastern Europe, as could perhaps that in Greece and Portugal. We should and could talk more about this, especially since Vox in Spain and Chega in Portugal have made inroads into the politics of these two southern European countries. What one can observe is that the right-wing authoritarian regimes in these Western European countries had endured long enough to become weakened and at the same time for the opposition to grow in strength, so that the democracy that ensued saw both political poles, left and right, in some sort of balance in terms of economic power and presence in the civil society. On the other hand, it is interesting that even much longer (and probably much tougher) Communist regimes in the East allowed for some opposition to survive, but in such a fragile form that – when the changes came – there was absolutely no question of a power balance, except perhaps in the Czech Republic with its strong liberal and social democratic tradition and in Poland, where such a counterweight was enabled by the Catholic tradition.